EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Did the World Create Itself? Time, Infinity and the Creator

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 1:1-2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 1 (Creation), end of Chapter 1 (the fourth proof, from time) and Chapter 2 (the world could not create itself; against creation from pre-existing matter) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 15 April 2024, on Zoom (the last shiur before Pesach)

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are

In the introduction to the essay Rav Saadia warned that we cannot **perceive** creation with our senses, so we must rely on reason, as every other theory must too. Chapter 1 then opened with his thesis: **Hashem created the world from nothing**, from **בראשית ברא אלהים**, since the word ***bara*** is used only of God and signifies creation from nothing. Then came **four rational proofs that the universe had a beginning**. Three were done last week:

#	Proof	In short
1	**Finitude**	Heaven and earth are finite, so their force is finite, so they began
2	**Design / composition**	Everything is beautifully put together, so there is a Maker
3	**Accidents (*mikrim*)**	Everything has happenings occurring to it and is inseparable from them, so it is itself a happening
4	**Time**	*Tonight*

Tonight's three steps

The argument builds in stages, "getting more and more":

1. **There was a beginning** (finishing Chapter 1 with the proof from time).
2. **The beginning did not happen by itself**: it was caused by something external (Chapter 2).
3. **It was not made from pre-existing matter**, against Plato (Chapter 2).

Part 1: Proof Four: Time

"I won't exaggerate. I spent many hours trying to understand it, and literally broke my head over it. It's a very complicated, very difficult one. We'll try our best to explain it, although it may not necessarily be convincing for yourself. **At least I'm not convinced by it.**"

The text

Time has three parts: **past, present and future**. The present is smaller than any instant, but for the sake of argument **I take the present as a point**, as one takes a point in a line. Now if a person tried in his thought to **ascend** from this point **upwards** (that is, back into the past), **he could not**, if time were infinite. **What is infinite, thought cannot traverse.**

The Rabbi illustrated: "It is now 6:08 on 15 April 2024. Let's mark that. Imagine the present freezes. Now go back a minute, and another, and back and back and back. You can't do that. It's impossible for our finite minds to traverse an infinity backwards." This goes back to **Aristotle: the infinite is that which cannot be traversed.** "So far so good."

Then the key step:

For the same reason, generation could not have traversed the infinite down to reach us. And if generation did not reach us, **we would not have been generated**; we and all that exists would not exist. **Since I find that I exist, I know that generation has passed through time until it reached me.** If time were not finite, generation could not have traversed it. And the same holds for the future as for the past.

He brings verses for time having a far end, such as **אנוש יביט מרחוק** (Iyov 36:25), man looks from afar: there is a "far" to look to, so time is finite.

Making sense of it: the Kalam

The classic commentaries did not help: "they basically said they couldn't understand it themselves." What finally helped was **an old academic paper (from about the 1940s) on the Kalam arguments for creation** in the Rishonim. The **Kalam** were the Arabic theologians whose methods were used by Rav Saadia, by the **Rambam**, and by **Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi** in the Kuzari.

The paper divides the argument into two parts:

Part	Content
The preamble	The infinite is **that which cannot be traversed**, and so **has no first, no beginning**. Rav Saadia speaks of traversing **in thought** because time, for Aristotle (whom he follows), exists in the mind: without a soul there would be no time
The argument proper	If anything's coming into being depended on **completing an infinite chain of prior generations**, nothing could ever come into being

And the key line:

If there is no first, there is no cause at all; and if there is no cause, there can be no effect.

The Rabbi's explanation

"What series is he talking about? **The series of generated human beings.** We are generated by our parents, who were generated by theirs, and so on. When I say generation, I don't mean the noun, *dor*. I mean the verb: being generated."

1. If the universe is eternal, **the chain of generation goes back infinitely**.
2. An infinite series **has no beginning**: "it's an inherent paradox to talk about the beginning of infinity."
3. **No first means no cause.**
4. **No cause means no effect.**
5. But **we exist**: Rav Saadia in the tenth century, and we in 2024. So the chain had a beginning.

"It's very hard to wrap your head around. But that's the best I think we can do with it."

Zeno's challenge and Rav Saadia's reply

Rav Saadia then quotes **"one of the deniers."** The Rabbi identified the objection with **Zeno**, the Greek philosopher of the fifth century BCE, who disputed this very premise: **we traverse the infinite every time we walk.**

"We can all walk a mile. Now cut the mile in half: half a mile. A quarter, an eighth, a sixteenth... Surely you could divide that into infinity, into the smallest atom, half of that atom, half of that. **The division of the mile is infinite, and yet you traverse it.**"

So the premise of the fourth proof, that the infinite cannot be traversed, seems destroyed.

Discussion. Mark suggested that walking a mile covers only a small section and "doesn't take you to the beginning." The Rabbi agreed that time is different, "but remember, we're using time as an example of the general concept, so if we destroy the premise, the whole thing falls." Another participant tried the reverse: if you keep halving, you never reach the end of the mile. "**I travelled a mile today. Fact.** So the proposition that anything infinite cannot be travelled is proven wrong."

Rav Saadia mentions two answers others gave, neither of which he accepts:

Answer	Idea
The indivisible atom	Division does not go on forever: there is a smallest thing that cannot be divided further. (The Rabbi asked whether anyone with a background in physics could say if that is still held today. "My granddaughter, but not me," said one participant. "Well, ask her for next week.")
The "leap"	You do not actually traverse the infinite parts; you **jump over** them

His own answer:

The infinite division of a mile is only in the mind. In theory I can halve it again and again; **in practice** you quickly reach a point too fine to divide. But time **actually passed**, in reality. **You cannot use something theoretical to refute something real.**

"A nice response. But if you got that, great. It's not crucial at all."

Further proofs, and Hiwi al-Balkhi

Rav Saadia says he has **more proofs**, some in his **commentary on the Torah** (which we no longer have) and some in his **refutation of Hiwi al-Balkhi**. The Rabbi read about Hiwi from Wikipedia:

- A **biblical critic of the late ninth century**, born in what is now **Afghanistan**.
- It is unclear whether he was a Jew or a member of a Christian sect; some say he belonged to the Bukharan Jewish community.
- He wrote **200 objections to the divine origin of the Torah**.
- His views spread so widely that **schoolmasters taught children from textbooks based on his criticisms**.
- **Rav Saadia had those books prohibited** and answered Hiwi in a book of refutation. **Both books are lost.**

Rav Saadia closes Chapter 1 by saying that when we see **the refutations of the other theories in Chapter 3**, our own position will be strengthened further.

Part 2: Chapter 2: Could the World Have Created Itself?

"When it became clear to me that the world had a beginning, I asked: **did things create themselves, or did something external create them?**"

"Clearly for us nowadays we would think this is absurd, the thought of something creating itself. But let's just see his logic." The Rabbi said it is actually **relevant to the Big Bang**:

Believing in the Big Bang is fine, and it may even corroborate the Torah's account (with the hint in the **Ramban**). "The problem is the Big Bang when you **don't posit anyone who created** the primordial soup." Where did it come from? "They'll tell you it was just there, it created itself." That, says Rav Saadia, is unacceptable, for three reasons.

The three proofs

#	Argument	The Rabbi's explanation
1	**Stronger after than before**	If something was strong enough, **while it did not yet exist**, to make itself, then once it exists it should be **even stronger** and able to make more of itself. But earth cannot make more earth. If it cannot do it from the stronger position, it could not have done it from the weaker one
2	**When?**	Before it existed, it was nothing, and **nothing cannot act**. After it existed, it no longer needed creating. **There is no third time** besides these, "and the present is too tiny to be sufficient." "If this non-existent thing *decided* to create itself, then it wasn't non-existent."
3	**The power to create implies the power not to**	Whatever can create itself must also be able **not** to. When would it have that ability? If after it exists, it already exists; if before, it is nothing. You would have **existence and non-existence together**, "completely wrong and nonsensical." Similar to the second, "but slightly different"

"I'm going through this quickly because it's straightforward, and I think most of us see the clear and inherent logic."

The verse: the prophet's rebuke of **Pharaoh**, who said **לי יאורי ואני עשיתני** (Yechezkel 29:3), "My river is mine, and I made myself." This is the rebuke of anyone who thinks a thing can make itself.

End of section two: four proofs that the world had a beginning; three proofs that it could not have made itself. "So therefore we must posit a creator." Rav Saadia has not yet said who that Creator is. That is Essay 2.

Part 3: Chapter 2 Continued: Against Pre-existing Matter

The final option is **Plato's**: there is a Creator, things cannot create themselves, but **He made the world from matter that existed eternally**. "The universe as we know it had a beginning, millions or billions of years ago. But when God created it, He created it from tiny matter which existed for eternity."

"To be honest, I've read about this in many different places. I've never really understood it." Rav Saadia's arguments, as the Rabbi presented them:

Argument one: what "creation" means

The very word ***creation*** means bringing something about **where there was nothing**. To speak of creation from something is to say there was no real beginning. "Logically, it makes more sense: when I say creation, creation means from nothing."

Argument two: two equal arguments?

Rav Saadia anticipates a clever objection:

You proved a Creator from what you **see**: everything in the world was made by someone. "If I see a clock, I assume it came from parts and was put together by someone. If I look at my clothes, someone wove them. If I look at my glasses, someone put them together." **No action without an actor.** But by the same senses, **everything you see was made *from something***. You have never seen anything made from nothing! "So why am I favouring one argument over the other?" Shouldn't the universe likewise come from pre-existing matter?

Rav Saadia's reply: whether the world is from nothing **is the very thesis under investigation**. You cannot bring as proof, in the middle of that investigation, **one of the two sides of the question itself**. "He tells you off. It's not the way you think."

"This just shows us how to use logic." The Rabbi added that **the Rambam wrote a treatise on logic** ("not easy reading"), and Rav Saadia is doing the same here: teaching how to frame an argument correctly.

Argument three: who decided which is which?

If the matter was eternal, then it and the Creator are **equally eternal**: "there's no hierarchy between God and matter." So why would the matter **obey**? Why should one be the maker and the other the made?

"There would have to be a third thing that assigned this one to be the Creator and that one to be the created. That's nonsense. **We only find a Creator and the created.** We didn't find a third thing."

Rav Saadia brings a few more arguments against Plato, which the class would finish quickly next time.

A Question for the Class

Chapter 3 is long. It examines **twelve other theories** of how the world came to be, "some very ancient and quite difficult to understand." Should the class go through them all, or skip them, given that **science now tells us the world had a beginning**?

"The only value I see is completeness, getting the whole picture, and **logic**: seeing how Saadia thinks. There is value. But I'm not sure it's worth spending a month or so."

Mark suggested studying **a selection, perhaps three of them**, to see the logic. "It's a good idea. Thank you, Mark." Over Pesach the Rabbi would analyse which are most relevant or most logical and choose some, inviting those listening to the recording to send their views too.

Summary

1. **Proof four, from time:** the infinite cannot be traversed; an infinite chain of generations **has no first, so no cause, so no effect**; we exist, so the chain began. The Rabbi found it the hardest proof and is not convinced by it, making sense of it only through a paper on the **Kalam**.
2. **Zeno's objection:** we cross infinitely divisible distances every day. **Rav Saadia's answer:** that infinity exists only **in thought**, while time actually passed. Others answered with the **indivisible atom** or the **leap**.
3. **More proofs** were in his lost commentary on the Torah and in his lost refutation of **Hiwi al-Balkhi**, the critic whose 200 objections were being taught to children.
4. **Chapter 2: nothing creates itself.** Three proofs: it would be **stronger** afterwards; there is **no time** at which it could have acted; the power to create implies the power **not** to. Pharaoh's **ואני עשיתני**. This is the problem with a Big Bang without a Creator.
5. **Against Plato's eternal matter:** creation means **from nothing**; you cannot prove a disputed thesis from **one side of the dispute**; and two equally eternal things leave **no reason for one to rule the other**.

Coming Up

Pesach break: no shiur for the next two Mondays. The class resumes **in three weeks**, finishing Chapter 2 briefly and moving to **a selection of the twelve theories in Chapter 3**.

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